

To the western front: British war plans and the 'military entente' with France before the first world war

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IN November 1914 the Historical Section of the Committee of Imperial Defence produced a 'Report on the Opening of the War'. In his notes towards this Report, Julian Corbett maintained that "our arrangements with the French Naval and Military Staff . . . fettered our freedom of action", with the result that "our Army . . . became committed as an integral part of the allied line and we had to forego all the advantages of operating independently on a line of our own and at our own selected moment, in order to break into the German scheme after it had developed".¹

Corbett's position is now widely shared. John Terraine has spoken of "the binding force" of the British government's commitment to a pre-arranged plan.² Paul Guinn has said that when the crisis of continental war arose in the summer of 1914, "no resistance could avail against the long-matured General Staff preparations"; and Samuel Williamson that the continuance of the staff talks assured the primacy of the strategy of continental intervention, that "the staff talks . . . were responsible for British presence on the western front".³ Nicholas d'Ombraïn, in the course of demonstrating emphatically that the C.I.D. failed to operate as a centre for strategic planning, has held that as a result of this failure, "the Government discovered in 1914 that its imagined freedom of choice had been jeopardized".⁴

All the above writers have closely connected the sending of the British Expeditionary Force to France and the kind of strategy which resulted from this with the pre-war conversations between the British and French General Staffs and the arrangements which these bodies made. They all imply that these arrangements not only had a momentum of their own which caused them to be put into action in August 1914, but also that they constituted in some way an obligation on the British government. A re-examination of questions associated with the military conversations will show that British plans were more flexible than has been thought

1. Quoted in N. d'Ombraïn, *War Machinery and High Policy* (Oxford, 1973), pp. 113-14.

2. J. Terraine, *Douglas Haig - the educated soldier* (London, 1963), p. 72.

3. P. Guinn, *British Strategy and Politics 1914-18* (Oxford, 1965), pp. 24-25; S. Williamson, *The Politics of Grand Strategy* (Harvard, 1969), pp. 200, 361.

4. d'Ombraïn, *op. cit.* p. 102.

and that the real motive for despatching the B.E.F. was of a kind not hitherto given its due weight.

The question of obligation will be addressed first. In April 1911 Sir Edward Grey provided the following justification for and account of the origins of the military conversations:

Early in 1906 the French said to us, "Will you help us if there is war with Germany?" We said, "We can't promise, our hands must be free." The French then urged that the military authorities should be allowed to exchange views, ours to say what they could do, the French to say how they would like it done, if we did side with France. Otherwise, as the French urged, even if we decided to support France, on the outbreak of war we shouldn't be able to do it effectively. We agreed to this.¹

Having dodged in this manner the 'great question' of whether, in the event of German aggression against France, Great Britain would be prepared to render France armed assistance,² the British government continued studiously to reserve its freedom of action. Despite continued contacts between the British and French military authorities, the government rigorously maintained, as did the sub-committee of the C.I.D. on the Military Needs of the Empire in its Report of July 1909, that the expediency of sending a military force abroad or of relying on naval means alone was a *matter of policy* which could only be determined when the occasion arose by the government of the day, as distinct from an *obligation*.³ In November 1912, in the course of drafting a letter concerning Anglo-French relations and the bearing on them of the naval and military conversations, Grey again avoided words suggested by the French ambassador, on the ground that they "would bind the two Governments if they decided to co-operate, to carry out plans made by the General Staffs".⁴ In March 1913 when Lord Hugh Cecil asserted in parliament that there was a widespread belief that Britain was under an obligation to send a large armed force out of the country to operate in Europe, Asquith interrupted to deny that this was the case. As he explained to Grey, such a challenge was one that he could not ignore.⁵

If there was no legal obligation, if there were at most only verbal assurances,⁶ was there none the less a moral obligation? Esher held that

1. Grey to Asquith 16 Apr. 1911, Grey, *Twenty-Five Years* (London, 1925), i. 94. This followed a request from Cruppi, the French foreign minister, for "an understanding which would not bind the two Governments to act but which would define what the joint action should be in case they had to cooperate". For "to defer such a definition until the crisis came would be very bad policy, for if . . . war came it might be too rapid in its progress to await the conclusion of the arrangements which would be necessary for effective cooperation". Bertie to Grey, 13 Apr. 1911 Gooch and Temperley (eds.), *British Documents on the Origins of the War 1898-1914* (London, 1926-38), vii, no. 207. See also Bertie to Grey, 17 Apr. 1907, Grey MSS. P.R.O. F.O. 800/50.

2. B.D. iii, nos. 210, 216.

3. Proceedings and Report in CAB 16/5.

4. B.D. x (ii), nos. 414, 415.

5. *Hansard* 5th series 1, cols 42-43, 10 Mar. 1913; Asquith to Grey, 14 Mar. 1913, Grey MSS. F.O. 800/100; B.D. vi, no. 467.

6. Grey did not deny Sir Arthur Nicolson's claim in Aug. 1914 that he had "over and over again promised M. Cambon that if Germany was the aggressor you would stand by France".

"the mere fact of the War Office plan having been worked out in detail with the French General Staff has certainly committed us to fight, whether the Cabinet likes it or not"; "Of course there is no treaty or convention, but how we can get out of the commitments of the General Staff with honour, I cannot understand".¹ McKenna thought so too: he told Asquith in October 1911 that "so long as conversations were carried on between the General Staffs, the danger (of British troops being used in France) existed".² (So did Harcourt in a different context: when Churchill in June 1912 proposed that a definite naval arrangement should be made with France without delay and went on, "This arrangement would come into force only if the two Powers were at any time allies in a war. It would not decide the question of whether they should be allies or not", Harcourt minuted: "Of course it would".³) The case of those who thought in this way would have been stronger if, as Esher wrote at one point, "by naval and military conventions entered into with our friends and allies, not perhaps specifically, but by inference and assumption, we are pledged to definite acts of war upon which the plans of other nations turn".⁴ However, this was not so. Joffre, the chief of the French General Staff, told the War Board in April 1913 that, because London "wanted to make no engagement in writing . . . we will thus act prudently in not depending upon English forces in our operational projects".⁵ Very little was made of such considerations at the British War Council of 5 August 1914.⁶

In August 1911, in conversation with Colonel Fairholme, military attaché to the British embassy in Paris, Joffre had said that he attached the very greatest importance to the co-operation of a British expeditionary force. When this conversation came to Asquith's notice, the prime minister wrote to Grey that "the French ought not to be encouraged, in present circumstances, to make their plans on any assumptions of this kind". Grey replied:

It would create consternation if we forbade our military experts to converse with the French. No doubt these conversations and our speeches have given an expectation of support. I do not see how that can be helped.⁷

Any such 'expectations' were a self-imposed problem for those who had them. Grey hoped Britain would be spared the consequences of any

He merely replied: "Yes, but he has nothing in writing". Henry Wilson, *Diary*, 2 Aug. 1914. According to Sazonov, Poincaré told him during a visit to St Petersburg in the summer of 1912 of *une convention verbale en vertu de laquelle l'Angleterre s'est déclarée prête à porter secours à la France par ses forces de terre comme par ses forces de mer, dans le cas d'une attaque de la part de l'Allemagne sur terre*. R. Marchand (ed.), *Un Livre Noir* (Paris, 1922-3), ii, p. 339.

1. Esher, *Journal*, 4 Oct. 1911, Esher to Brett 12 Mar. 1913, in M. V. Brett and Esher (eds.), *Journals and Letters of Reginald, Viscount Esher* (London, 1934-8), iii, pp. 61, 122.

2. Notes by McKenna of conversation with Asquith, 20 Oct. 1911, McKenna MSS. 4/2.

3. Note by Harcourt on memo by Churchill, 15 June 1912, Harcourt MSS.

4. Quoted in Williamson, *op. cit.* p. 309.

5. *Ibid.* p. 222.

6. War Council minutes, 5 Aug. 1914, CAB 42/1/2.

7. Bertie to Grey, 25 Aug. 1911, B.D. vi, no. 475; Asquith to Grey, 5 Sept. Grey to Asquith, 8 Sept. 1911 in Grey, *op. cit.* i, p. 95.

failure to live up to others' excessive expectations of her by the constant caveat that the French and British governments were not committed by the plans for joint action worked out by their General Staffs.¹ This attitude, as we have seen, had its effect on Joffre and on French War Plans (though Sir William Nicholson for one (the C.I.G.S., 1908-12), evidently thought that the French were entitled to some return on their expectations).² In March 1913, when Asquith denied Lord Hugh Cecil's assertion, Paul Cambon the French ambassador had to admit that however unfortunate its effects might be, the prime minister's statement was true.³ Sir Henry Wilson, who as Director of Military Operations had done more than anyone else to further the cause of military planning with the French, got the impression from this incident that the Cabinet had decided *not* to help the French on land. Although he called them "Cowards, Blackguards, and Fools" he did not dispute that they were free to decide whether or not to aid France in this way.⁴ Even the optimistic Isvolsky had had to point out from Paris the difference between the Franco-Russian convention and the Anglo-French 'accords' – that the latter, being signed only by the General Staffs, were for that reason not *obligatoire pour le Gouvernement*; and it indicates the lack of regard in which what had been done was held on the part of both the British Foreign Office and the French authorities (whatever 'hopes' the latter might have entertained) that Bertie in June 1913 was still receiving feelers and picking up hints "that there ought to be something definite to rely on".⁵

Finally, though even Haldane was to admit in conversation with Lord Lansdowne in August 1914 that there was "an implied engagement" (merely insisting that it was "clearly recognized by both sides that our liability to send out the Expeditionary Force was one to which we could not be expected to give effect except in circumstances which enabled us to do so without incurring too serious a risk", and maintaining that this was quite a different "engagement" from that implied by the current distributions of the French and British fleets⁶) there were considerable political obstacles in the way of regarding the military plans as a commitment. McKenna, who as First Lord of the Admiralty had revealed himself

1. "It was always understood that (the conversations) did not commit either Government to go to war to assist the other, but were to enable the respective naval and military authorities to carry out cooperation at short notice, if that was in any emergency the decision of their Governments." Minute by Grey, 5 May on Nicholson to Grey, 4 May 1912, Grey MSS. F.O. 800/94.

2. Nicholson to Churchill, 2 Sept. Nicholson to Haldane 16 Dec. 1911, ADM 116/3474.

3. Grey to Bertie, 11 Mar. 1913 B.D. x(ii), no. 466.

4. Wilson Diary, 11 Mar. 1913; contrast d'Ombraïn *op. cit.* p. 113, n. 97. Major Grant-Duff also disputed Esher's view that Britain was "absolutely compromised". He noted in his Diary for 6 Nov. 1911: "the understanding has always been absolutely clear that the negotiations committed no one to anything." Grant-Duff MSS. 2/1. (The Grant-Duff Diary is quoted by kind permission of Mrs S. S. Grant).

5. Isvolsky to Sazonov, 5 Dec. 1912 *Livre Noir*, i, p. 362; and see minute by Crowe on Buchanan to Grey, 3 Apr. 1914, F.O. 371/2092; memo by Bertie, 23 June 1913, Bertie MSS. F.O. 800/166.

6. Lord Newton, *Lord Lansdowne* (London, 1929), p. 441.

at what came to be known as the 114th meeting of the C.I.D. on 23 August 1911 as categorically opposed to War Office schemes for the use of British troops in France, constituted in his own person one such obstacle. He announced to Asquith on 20 October 1911 his intention of raising the question of communications between the British and French General Staffs in the Cabinet and of using information obtained in the C.I.D. in support of a case against them about which he wished to get in touch beforehand with other ministers. Asquith, who had already agreed at the beginning of the month with Esher about the impossibility of having an English force concentrated in France within a week of the outbreak of war when the majority of the Cabinet had never even heard of the plan, supposed that McKenna wished to concert his action with Morley and Harcourt. McKenna agreed and said there might be others¹; and indeed, in addition to Harcourt, who had recently described the landing of British troops to assist a French army on the Meuse as "a criminal folly", Runciman had condemned the "rampageous strategists" who did not draw his distinction "between action by sea and the certain destruction of British troops in Belgium or France".² Loreburn had also written in a long letter to Grey:

I greatly fear that France expects our military and naval support. I believe you could not give it, if you wished, in this which is a purely French quarrel. I believe you could not carry it in the present House of Commons, except by a majority very very largely composed of Conservatives and with a very large number of the Ministerial side against you. And this would mean that the present Government could not carry on.

Loreburn submitted that "it is not right to leave the French in the illusion they will have our material support".³

When the matter of the conversations came before the Cabinet in November 1911, Asquith pointed out that "all questions of policy have been and must be reserved" for the decision of the Cabinet and that it was "quite outside the function of military or naval officers to prejudge" such questions. He added that he believed that this was fully recognized by the French government and Grey seconded this. Nevertheless, the Cabinet voted by 15 to 5 in favour of a resolution to the effect that "no communications should take place between the General Staff here and the Staffs of other countries which can directly or indirectly commit this country to military and naval intervention".⁴

In the autumn of 1912 the Cabinet watched closely the course of developments connected with Cambon's proposed formula to express the charac-

1. McKenna notes, 20 Oct. 1911, McKenna MSS. 4/2; Esher, *Journals, op. cit.* iii, p. 62, 4 Oct. 1911.

2. Harcourt to Runciman, 26 Aug., Runciman to Harcourt, 24 Aug. 1911, Runciman MSS.

3. Loreburn to Grey, 25 Aug. 1911, Grey MSS. F.O. 800/99.

4. Asquith to the King, 2, 16 Nov. 1911, CAB 41/33, Asquith MSS., vol. 6; draft by Asquith of Cabinet resolutions, 15 Nov. 1911, *ibid.*; T. Wilson (ed.), *The Political Diaries of C. P. Scott* (London, 1970), p. 61.

ter and purpose of the *Entente*. The content and phrasing of Grey's letter to Cambon of 22 November 1912 was as much the work of the Cabinet as of Grey himself.¹ With a body so constituted and possessed of such an outlook Sir Arthur Nicolson, permanent under-secretary at the Foreign Office, had ample grounds for the opinion he expressed to Buchanan in April 1914, when he said that he was "afraid that should war break out on the continent the likelihood of our despatching any expeditionary force is extremely remote . . .".²

The premise upon which the plans of both the War Office and the Admiralty for giving armed support to the French were based was this: that without such support the French would be defeated by the Germans. General Ewart, Wilson's predecessor as Director of Military Operations, cast his reflections upon France early in 1909 in the following way:

The course of events in recent years has altered the balance of power in Europe once again and, as in the past, our foreign policy aims at redressing the inequality by supporting the weaker side. The chief weakness of our potential allies lies in a doubt as to the ability of one of them to withstand the military forces of the stronger group until the military strength of their partner can be brought to bear, or until the slow, if perhaps sure, pressure of sea power can take effect.³

Wilson, two years later, was more direct:

In the case of our remaining neutral Germany will fight France single-handed. The armies of Germany and the fleets of Germany are much superior to those of France, and the results of such a war can scarcely be doubted . . . It follows that in a single-handed war France would in all human probability be defeated . . .⁴

Both Admiralty and War Office agreed with the maxim that the best way to win campaigns was to have decisive numbers at the decisive place at the decisive time. Their solutions to the problem of relieving pressure on the French army were geared either to the achieving of superior numbers for the *Entente* against the Germans or the obverse of this – the engineering of inferior numbers for the Germans against the *French*. As Churchill put it *à propos* military intervention: "The reason for sending a British army either to France or Belgium is to secure, either by addition to the French or by subtraction from the German force, a preponderance of strength on the decisive front at the decisive moment."⁵ The "decisive

1. Asquith to the King, 1, 21 Nov. 1912, Asquith MSS. vol. 6.

2. Nicolson to Buchanan, 7 Apr. 1914, Carnock MSS. F.O. 800/373; and see Bertie to Grey, 3 Aug. 1914, B.D. xi, no. 566; J. Gooch, *The Plans of War* (London, 1974), p. 295.

3. Memo. by Ewart, 8 Mar. 1909 'The Value to a Foreign Power of an Alliance with the British Empire', W.O. 106/45 E1/1 – also in Grey MSS., F.O. 800/102.

4. Memo. by Wilson, 11 Aug. 1911, W.O. 106/47A E2/23; see also appendix A to General Staff memo., 'The Military Aspect of the Continental Problem', 12 Aug. 1911, para 15, CAB 38/19/47. Grant-Duff Diary 17, 25 Aug. 1911, Grant-Duff MSS. 2/1.

5. Memo. by Churchill, 16 Oct. 1911, ADM 116/3474. This and other documents from this file are printed in my article, 'The War Office, Churchill, and the Belgian Option, August to December 1911', to be published in *Bulletin of Historical Research* No. 122 (1977).

point" was defined by Henry Wilson as "the point where the German and French armies met for a decision".¹

Asquith opened the War Council of 5 August 1914 with these words: "The situation was not unlike one which had constantly been considered, but with regard to which no decision had ever been reached."² What he meant was that one of the plans put forward for saving the French had formally been decided upon. This was strictly correct. However, by that time the strategic option originally proposed by the Admiralty was, for a number of reasons, no longer available.

On two occasions before the war the alternative schemes of the Admiralty and the General Staff for providing the French with armed support had been examined on their merits. The first of these was provided by a sub-committee of the Committee of Imperial Defence called by Asquith in October 1908 to consider circumstances in which the British Army might be called upon to operate either alone or with other Powers.³ At the meetings of this sub-committee the Admiralty proved most reluctant to reveal its intentions. It did emerge, however, from an outburst on the part of Sir John Fisher, the First Sea Lord, at the first meeting on 3 December 1908, that he considered that the British Army should be restricted to operations consisting of sudden descents on the German coasts, the recovery of Heligoland and the garrisoning of Antwerp. He went on to speak of "ten miles of hard sand on the Pomeranian coast which is only ninety miles from Berlin. Were the British Army to seize and entrench that strip, a million Germans would find occupation."⁴ His preference was evidently for such coastal operations: he wrote to Esher in March 1909 that he had been studying one "of inestimable value only involving 5,000 men and some guns, and horses about 500 – a mere fleabite! but a collection of these fleabites would make Wilhelm scratch himself with fury!"⁵ The sub-committee, however, accepted the General Staff's view that "no relief could be given to the armies of France by any threat by the British Army to make a descent on the coast of Germany, since the latter Power has ample troops both for watching its own coasts and for an attack on France, and those detailed on the former service would not in any case be used for active operations". It also considered that such economic pressure as would be exerted by a blockade of Germany would not be felt "sufficiently soon to save France" if she was attacked in overwhelming force. Consequently the General Staff plan was considered by the sub-committee to be the more valuable one and the schemes of the Admiralty were, in McKenna's word, "discarded".⁶

1. Memo. by Wilson, 'Appreciation of the Political and Military Situation in Europe', para. 25, 20 Sept. 1911, W.O. 106/47A E2/26. 2. CAB 42/1/2.

3. This was composed of Asquith (chairman), Crewe, McKenna, Haldane, Hardinge, Esher, Fisher, French, Nicholson, Ewart, and Slade (replaced as D.N.I. by Bethell in Mar. 1909).

4. R. H. S. Bacon, *Life of Lord Fisher* (London, 1929), ii, pp. 182–3.

5. A. J. Marder (ed.), *Fear God and Dread Nought* (London, 1952–9), ii, pp. 232–3.

6. C.I.D. Sub-Committee Report, 24 July 1909, CAB 16/5; McKenna, 'Remarks by the Admiralty on Proposal (B) of Memo by the General Staff 130B', Aug. 1911, CAB 38/19/48.

The second occasion was in the course of the Agadir crisis of 1911. Nervous, and unsure about Germany's real intentions, the Government called a meeting, although not a full one, of the Committee of Imperial Defence, for 23 August. This was, in Grant-Duff's words, "to settle their plans in case of the worst". At this time the Admiralty revealed that it had failed to improve on the idea of "fleabites": Imperial Germany was still expected to scratch herself to death. Both McKenna and Sir Arthur Wilson, Fisher's successor, spoke unconvincingly of a close blockade of the whole German North Sea coast and of one division of the British Army embarked in transports and taking part in operations against Wilhelmshaven and Heligoland, Bremerhaven and Cuxhaven, in this way retaining ten German divisions on the coast and away from the main theatre of war and thereby making a material contribution to the Allied cause.¹ They were thoroughly routed by the Army, Sir William Nicholson gaining his revenge for Fisher's having in 1908 called the despatch of British troops to the front in a Continental war "an act of suicidal idiocy" by demonstrating that the class of operations envisaged by the Admiralty was not only anachronistic and "doomed to failure" but, in his considered opinion, "madness".²

In the aftermath of this meeting Asquith could not avoid saying that: Sir A. Wilson's "plan" can only be described as puerile, and I have dismissed it at once as wholly impracticable. The impression left on me, after consideration of the whole discussion . . . is that, in principle, the General Staff scheme is the only alternative . . .³

Under pressure from Haldane, which included a threat to resign, for a modernization of the Admiralty to create an institution which would in future co-operate more readily with the War Office, the prime minister in October moved Churchill there from the Home Office and converted the principle into practice.⁴ Sir Henry Wilson saw Churchill on 21 November 1911 and recorded afterwards: "He will play in with us [*i.e.* the W.O.] all he can . . .".⁵ Churchill himself wrote to Haldane on 8 January 1912: "Now let us at once begin the transport arrangements. They have hung fire since September."⁶ Moreover, in Churchill's time there, the Admiralty substituted an observational blockade of the German coast for a close blockade. As a result they removed themselves from a position from which they could have launched any combined operations in that area.⁷

1. Grant-Duff Diary, 17 Aug. 1911, Grant-Duff MSS. 2/1; minutes of 114th meeting of C.I.D. CAB 2/2/2.

2. *Ibid.*; A. J. Marder, *From the Dreadnought to Scapa Flow* (Oxford, 1961), i, p. 387; Fisher's views were unchanged: see his notes for Churchill, 30 Oct. 1911 in R. S. Churchill, *Winston S. Churchill*, companion vol. 2, part 2, p. 1303 (London, 1969).

3. Asquith to Haldane, 31 Aug. 1911, Haldane MSS. 5909; also 9 Sept: 'The arguments as put in the W.O. letters are, of course, conclusive as against Sir A. W.'s scheme.' *ibid.*

4. d'Ombrain, *op. cit.* pp. 255-8; Sir F. Maurice, *Haldane* (London, 1937), i, pp. 283-4.

5. Wilson Diary, 21 Nov. 1911.

6. Churchill to Haldane, 8 Jan. 1912, Haldane MSS. 5909.

7. Marder, *op. cit.* i, pp. 367-77.

These developments since 1908, together with the fact that the premise on which all planning was based was no less strong and the consciousness of it more widespread – as indicated by Churchill's and Lloyd George's and Grey's questions at the session of 23 August 1911 about the likelihood of a French defeat – meant that in 1914 the Government effectively had only the alternatives provided by the War Office to turn to.

In conversation with Esher on 4 October 1911 Asquith, whilst condemning the Admiralty's proposals and disclosing his own reluctance to see more than four divisions of the British army despatched to France, said that he still wanted "the Belgian plan" to be "worked out".¹ He was referring to the scheme presented by the General Staff to the 1908–9 sub-committee. This scheme admitted of the deflection of the British army across the French frontier to the right of the Belgian army. It also remarked that

If . . . before we were actually committed to French soil, it became evident that Germany intended to disregard the neutrality of Belgium and Luxembourg, the question arises whether we could not give more assistance to France and the common cause by landing our expeditionary force in northern Belgium, and by operating thence against the flank of the German advance.

Such action, it was thought, would have the advantage of directly covering Antwerp. The General Staff gave preference to a plan in which "the British force shall be concentrated in rear of the left of the French army, primarily as a reserve" and it was this plan which the sub-committee described as a valuable one and of which it concluded that all the necessary details should be worked out. The General Staff, however, had gone on to say that the possibility of the British force's being called upon to cover Antwerp had not been lost sight of and that plans would also be worked out for landings in Belgium with a view to this operation.²

Nicholas d'Ombraïn, for one, has claimed that, after this reference to it, the Belgian scheme was ignored.³ This, however, is far from being the case. Historians have concentrated upon the development of the "W.F. Scheme", which d'Ombraïn, probably correctly, interprets as shorthand for "With France".⁴ It has not been appreciated that there was also a "With Belgium" scheme. This was not allocated any initials, nor was any great amount of separate planning done upon it. Both were unnecessary. For the "Belgian" scheme was interchangeable with the "W.F." scheme. It was an option available to the British Army once it had disembarked at French ports and it was an option that was still available in August 1914. Had it been taken up, the course of the war would not have been the same.

In their plans to save the French from defeat the General Staff had, from the outset, to contend with a number of imponderables. They did not know, when they began, whether they would be involved in a war with

1. d'Ombraïn, *op. cit.*, pp. 105–6.

2. C.I.D. Sub-Committee, report and appendix IV, CAB 16/5.

3. d'Ombraïn, *op. cit.*, p. 97.

4. *Ibid.* p. 89.

Germany in defence of Belgian neutrality, or in a war between Germany and France. If in the latter, they did not know whether the neutrality of Belgium would be maintained or whether it would be violated by Germany nor, if it was violated, to what extent or at what point in the war: whether the Germans would confine their operations to the area south of the river Meuse or whether they would deploy to both north and south of that obstacle; whether the Germans would invade Belgium at the start of a Franco-German war or at some later stage in the course of such a war. They did not know how the Dutch would react to a violation of their territory that a German advance north of the Meuse would involve, nor what effect a closure of the Scheldt might have upon the safety of Antwerp. They did not know what the attitude of the Belgians themselves would be to any violation of Belgium, whether confined to the country south of the Meuse or not. They had also to consider the extra-European situation.¹

Matters were advanced somewhat by the sub-committee of 1908-9 taking the view that "the decision of the question of whether Great Britain should intervene on behalf of France cannot . . . be left to turn on the mere point of violation of Belgian neutrality".² But the General Staff remained unable to fix the "decisive place" and the "decisive time" with any precision. Captain Ommanney criticized Grant-Duff's memorandum of January 1907 for stopping short "at the most interesting and vital point which is whether [British troops] should be employed in France or Belgium".³ In July 1908 Grant-Duff was saying that the decisive point of the struggle would be "where the main armies of France (or the Allies) and of Germany met": "it would be wisest to concentrate all that we can

1. Only one memorandum, of remarkable perspicience, went to the heart of the matter. Colonel Adye, in a long note on a memo by Major Grant-Duff of Jan. 1907, wrote:

In discussing possible British military operations in Belgium we need consider one situation only, that which would be brought about by a conflict between France and Germany in which the latter, for strategic reasons, decides to violate Belgian territory . . . If Germany decides to violate neutral territory it may be that she will not confine that violation to Belgium, but, by moving north of the Meuse, force the line of that river and obtain the advantage of the superior railway facilities north of Cologne without increasing the risk of British intervention . . .

It may be assumed that the initiative will rest with Germany, and, had she a Napoleon to inspire her policy and direct her armies in the field, there is little doubt that an advance through Belgium . . . would be undertaken.

Grant-Duff's memo. of 4 Jan. 1907, 'A War with Germany in the defence of the neutrality of Belgium', and Adye's note, are in W.O. 106/46. Contrast also memo. by Grant-Duff, July 1908, 'Military Policy in a war with Germany' *ibid.*; General Staff memo., 27 Nov. 1908, appendix IV to C.I.D. Sub-Committee CAB 16/5; General Staff memo., 23 Sept. 1905, 'The Violation of the Neutrality of Belgium during a Franco-German War', pp. 1, 3, CAB 38/10.

2. C.I.D. Sub-Committee Report, para. 5 CAB 16/5. The attitude of the Foreign Office was best revealed by Hardinge on a memo by Crowe of 15 Nov. 1908: "Supposing that France violated the neutrality of Belgium in a war against Germany, it is, under present circumstances, doubtful whether England or Russia would move a finger to maintain Belgian neutrality, which [sic] if the neutrality of Belgium were violated by Germany it is probable that the converse would be the case." B.D. viii, no. 311.

3. Notes by Ommanney on Grant-Duff, memo. 4 Jan. 1907, W.O. 106/46. These are taken by d'Ombrain, *op. cit.* (p. 104) to have been made in Sept. 1907, but may well have been made later. The dating reads 'Sept/10'. Adye's notes are undated.

in that theatre of war in which our small force can earliest make themselves felt. That theatre is France or Belgium . . .".¹ Henry Wilson's definition of this, in September 1911, was "either in, or in the neighbourhood of, the Ardennes". As a result of his own extensive fieldwork on the geography of the Franco-German frontier he had become convinced that the main German effort would be made through the ninety mile gap between Verdun and Maubeuge. He believed, and continued to believe, that Germany would not move north of the Meuse.²

Because of, rather than despite, these imponderables, the schemes produced by the War Office advocated and contained a degree of flexibility. They met the General Staff's self-imposed requirement of November 1908 that:

We have . . . in considering what military measures we might take, if it were necessary to give aid to either France or Belgium . . . so to frame our plans that they may be capable of instant modification during the first days of mobilization, should the developments of the situation demand it.³

In this they were helped by a fact to which the General Staff drew attention in April 1907, namely:

that the same set of railway lines from Calais, Boulogne, and Havre would lead British forces disembarking at these ports equally to the French left or the Belgian right.⁴

Although a poor opinion of the state of the Belgian army and reservations about whether the Belgian government would actively defend its country against invasion had helped the War Office to prefer the scheme it did in late 1908,⁵ the Directorate of Military Operations in Sir Henry Wilson's time was fully alive to the value to England and France of a positive attitude on the part of the minor states of the Low Countries. In conversation with the French military attaché in March 1911 Wilson had considered a German violation of Belgium as certain and revealed that he counted on the four divisions of the Belgian army.⁶ In April, in a note for the C.I.G.S., he stated:

It would possibly, and indeed probably, change the whole course of the campaign if the Belgians could be induced to put their fortresses of Liège and Namur into a better state of defence and if they would trust more to their field army and less to their fortress of Antwerp.⁷

1. Memo. by Grant-Duff, July 1908, W.O. 106/46.

2. See memo. by Wilson, 12 Aug. 1911, W.O. 106/47A E2/25; Wilson at 114th C.I.D., p. 5, CAB 2/2/2; memo by Wilson, 20 Sept. 1911, W.O. 106/47A E2/26. This became the accepted orthodoxy. Not even Kitchener could shift it well into Aug. 1914. Sir George Arthur, *Life of Lord Kitchener* (London, 1920), iii, pp. 22-23.

3. C.I.D. Sub-Committee, appendix IV, para. 4, CAB 16/5.

4. Memo. by General Staff, 8 Apr. 1907, 'Our Position as regards the Low Countries', CAB 18/24.

5. See *ibid.*; memo. by Grierson, 1 Jan. 1906, W.O. 106/44; memo. by Grant-Duff and Adye notes, Jan. 1907, W.O. 106/46; Sub-Committee Report para. 19 and appendix IV, CAB 16/5.

6. Pellé to Berteaux, 7 Mar. 1911, *Documents Diplomatiques Français* 2nd series, xiii, no. 180.

7. Note by Wilson, 24 Apr. 1911, W.O. 106/47A E2/21; B.D. vi, no. 460.

Wilson needed no prompting to discuss with Churchill the value to Britain and France of a Belgium actively hostile to Germany, and in reply to the latter's question at the end of August 1911, What should be our foreign policy, speaking of course from the military point of view?, he replied:

My opinion is that, for the single and specific case of an unwarranted attack by Germany on France or an attempt by Germany to seize or absorb Belgium, England and France should have an offensive and defensive alliance and in this Belgium would join . . . Denmark ought to be brought into it and I take it for granted that Russia is already there.

A Belgium, hostile to Germany, would mean that the line of the Meuse was secure, that the fortresses of Namur and Liège and the work at Huy were impregnable. It would mean an open and friendly country for us to operate in, it would therefore mean a constant and ever increasing menace to the German right flank and the German line of communication; and most important of all, it would mean that the superiority in German numbers could not be brought into play.¹

Wilson sent a copy of this to his chief, Sir William Nicholson, and in another letter elaborated and defended conclusions which, he said, were the outcome of years of study. Nicholson was unreceptive. The acceptance of the proposal, he claimed, "would involve a radical change in our scheme for supporting France in the event of that Power being attacked by Germany". While he appreciated that "our Expeditionary Force cannot reinforce the left of the French line if it is to be used in Belgium in the manner indicated", he missed Wilson's most important point concerning numbers. This was that from the "safe" base of northern Belgium "a force of eight to ten divisions could operate on the right flank of the German advance".²

Wilson was not deterred by Nicholson's response. Having on the night of 4 September put his views personally before Sir Edward Grey, and not without effect, on 9 September he impressed on the French military attaché, Huguet, the value of Belgian active support and of Anglo-Belgian operations. Huguet immediately went to see Cambon and on his return told Wilson what the latter had until then been ignorant of – "where the French G.S. want us to go and what their plans are".³ On the very next day Wilson began to write a long paper on the political and military situation of Europe which Churchill had requested a few days

1. Wilson Diary, 28 Aug. 1911; Wilson to Churchill, 29 Aug. 1911, ADM 116/3474.

2. Wilson Diary, 29, 31 Aug. 1911; Nicholson to Wilson, 1 Sept., to Churchill 2 Sept. 1911, ADM 116/3474. This point had not been neglected by Churchill when he followed up his original questions with a note to the D.M.O. on 30 Aug. 1911: "If the withdrawal of two divisions from the decisive centre led to the utilisation of the Belgian Army, would it not mean a far larger subtraction from German strength at the decisive point? If Belgium were our ally wd it not be better to send the whole army to Antwerp and act against the german flank than simply to take posts on the left of the French?" *ibid.* In conversation with Churchill on 31 Aug. Wilson had mentioned the figure of ten or twelve German divisions being subtracted from the decisive battle by Anglo-Belgian co-operation on the German flank. Churchill to Lloyd George, 31 Aug. 1911, R. S. Churchill, *op. cit.* companion vol. 2, part 2, pp. 1118–19.

3. Wilson Diary, 4, 9 Sept. 1911; Williamson, *op. cit.* p. 179, n. 36.

before. In this he maintained that the importance of a Belgium friendly to France and England "can scarcely be overrated", dwelt at length on the difficulties which would face a German force advancing to the south of the Meuse and Sambre from sudden and surprise attacks of the "Belgian and English" armies and reminded the Government that "the larger the force detached by the Germans from the decisive point the better it would be for France and ourselves".¹ The day after he finished this and sent it to the C.I.G.S. the Foreign Office sent Ronald Macleay, who had been selected to go over to Brussels to find out how the land lay, to him for briefing.² In October he was convinced that "we ought to be able to snaffle these Belgians" and put further pressure on Sir Arthur Nicolson for overtures towards them.³ Huguet was being more than generous and more loyal to Wilson than the other way round, when he maintained that Wilson remained "loyal" to joint action with France.⁴ It had not been coincidence, but rather the result of what at the very least was ambivalence on the part of Henry Wilson, that the French had provided him when he was in Paris on 29 September with all the relevant information on the concentration areas of the French northern armies and for the B.E.F.⁵ There was, after all, a considerable difference between taking up a position in the triangle Maubeuge-Brussels-Liège (as Churchill was suggesting) or along a line Liège-Givet-Mézières, and concentrating between Arras, St Quentin and Cambrai as in the "W.F." scheme.⁶

Henry Wilson's answers to questions posed by Churchill and passed on to him by Nicholson at the end of October 1911 make the position even more clear and deserve to be quoted in full:

Q. 1. What, if any, would be the advantages to be gained from a friendly and allied Belgium and what modifications would it be worth while making in the present plan?

A. 1. The advantage would be very great and if estimated in divisions might amount to the withdrawal of 14 to 16 German divisions from the main theatre. *No great modifications in our present plan would be required.*

1. Wilson Diary, 5, 10 Sept. 1911; Wilson memo. 20 Sept. 1911, W.O. 106/47A E2/26, my italics.

2. Wilson Diary, 20, 21 Sept. 1911. Macleay was able to report that no secret agreement had been made between Belgium and Germany such as would allow the passage of troops by the latter through Belgian territory and more especially through the south-eastern corner of Belgium, and that in his opinion the Belgian reaction to any such German action would in great measure be governed by the assurances of support she may receive from Great Britain. Grey congratulated him on exploring "this delicate ground with promptness, ability and discretion". Macleay to Nicolson and minute by Grey, 29 Sept. 1911, F.O. 371/1050/39992.

3. Wilson Diary, 24, 27 Oct. 1911; see Macleay to Nicolson, 7, 28 Oct. 1911, Carnock MSS. F.O. 800/351.

4. Williamson, *op. cit.* p. 180, n. 40. It was Nicholson, not Wilson or French, who remained loyal.

5. Wilson Diary, 29 Sept. 1911.

6. Churchill in a memo. of 16 Oct. 1911 considered that "the strategic advantage of placing the British Army behind the line of the Belgian Meuse wd appear to exceed any that can be obtained from prolonging the French left on the Verdun-Maubeuge front": ADM 116/3474; Williamson, *op. cit.* p. 179, n. 36; memo. of meeting between General Dubail and General Wilson, 20 July 1911, B.D. vii, no. 640.

- Q. 2. On what day could an Anglo-Belgian Army be concentrated behind the Liège-Namur line? Could it be concentrated by the 17th day?
- A. 2. The answers to these questions depend on what day the British and Belgian mobilizations are ordered. If these mobilizations are ordered on the *same day* as those of France and Germany, the Anglo-Belgian Army could be concentrated on the 15th or 16th day, possibly, with good arrangements, by the 14th day.
- Q. 3. Should it go through Maubeuge or through Lille, or by Ostend and Ghent, or several of them? And what should be the base?
- A. 3. The British force would enter Belgium from France and not from the Belgian coast. The base would be in France.¹

Wilson returned to these arguments in April 1912: if Belgium actively opposed Germany, the action of the armies of the *Triple Entente* would be at a great advantage; even if Germany seized Liège the use of the Belgian railways could be denied her and the combined British and Belgian forces would be in a position seriously to harass the German right flank and communications; "if Belgium is co-belligerent with the British and French armies the freedom of action afforded to the combined British and Belgian forces would probably neutralize the superior German numbers".² He was confident that, if the Belgians called on Britain for help directly their territory was violated, he could put 150,000 men at the decisive point in time. Bridges, the military attaché in Brussels, mis-handled his approaches along these lines to Jungbluth the Belgian chief of staff and Michel the Belgian war minister by implying that the British would come whether they were asked or not and possibly before Belgian territory had been violated. The Foreign Office had to step in to disavow any such intentions.³

Wilson still did not consider the Belgian option as closed. In October 1912 he transmitted to Grey through Seely a minute in which he pointed out the difference to England and the French of the value of a friendly Belgium, which he put at twelve to sixteen divisions⁴ and in November 1912 as a result of his insistence that the Belgian position be cleared up Sir John French once more approached the Foreign Office.⁵ When at

1. Note by Wilson, 30 Oct. 1911, W.O. 106/47A, my italics in A.1. This was elaborated on by Wilson in Nov. and finally initialled by Nicholson in Dec. 1911. To Answer 1 was added: "The area of detraining and of concentration would alone be altered." The estimate of the number of German divisions detached from the decisive point became "10 to 15". It was agreed that "in the opening stages of the war the British Force ought never to lose touch with the French Army if the latter has to fall back". Note by Wilson, 21 Nov. 1911, *ibid.* and enclosure in Nicholson to Haldane, 16 Dec. 1911, ADM 116/3474.

2. 'Attitude of Great Britain towards Belgium in the event of the violation of the neutrality of the latter Power by Germany', Apr. 1912, W.O. 106/48 E2/27.

3. Wilson Diary, 7 Apr. 1912; J. E. Helmreich, 'Belgian Concern over Neutrality and British Intentions 1906-14', *Journal of Modern History*, xxxvi (1964), pp. 423-4.

4. Wilson Diary, 22 Oct. 1912; note by Wilson, 21 Oct. 1912, W.O. 106/48.

5. Wilson Diary, 18 Nov. 1912. This led to an exchange between Nicolson and Villiers at the turn of the year. The ambassador reported: "Our reception as friends or enemies should we advance troops into Belgium to repel a German aggression would depend upon circumstances ... I am of opinion that if we were to take action before the Germans actually entered Belgium, or in any case without agreement with the Belgian Government, or without an invitation from

the end of that month he told General de Castelnau that on no account must the French be the first to violate Belgian neutrality, this was still more in the direction of keeping the Belgian option open and reducing Belgian disquiet concerning the *Entente* than it was to do with agreeing with Paris on the treatment of a hostile Belgium.¹ Finally, at the War Council on 5 August 1914 Wilson revealed that a month before he had sent three officers to France:

They had worked out an alternative scheme [to the standing W. F. Scheme] in co-operation with the French General Staff, according to which the British force might concentrate at Amiens, whence they could very easily be despatched in any direction, according as the situation might develop.²

The appreciation that the "W.F." scheme was not the only one available may have encouraged staff officers, both before the war and at its outbreak, to express differing views as to the best strategy for the army to adopt.³ Why, however, in August 1914, when the Belgian scheme was admitted to be still technically feasible, when it had been claimed that it would occupy greater German numbers than six British divisions fighting on the French left⁴ and that this difference of between six and 12/16 "may quite easily decide the campaign one way or another"⁵, and when the imponderable of the attitude of the Belgians themselves was removed in a favourable sense, was the "W.F." scheme preferred?

The decision for war was a *political* decision. It was taken on the ground of the *Entente*.⁶ So far as the maintenance of Cabinet unity was concerned

them, we should be considered to have violated the neutrality of the country and thus to be enemies." The diplomatic position rested with Grey's assurance that as long as Belgian neutrality was not violated by any other Power "we should certainly not send troops ourselves into their territory". H. Nicolson, *Lord Carnock* (London, 1930), pp. 398-400; Grey to Villiers, 7 Apr. 1913, B.D. viii, no. 330. Sir J. French was much more in harmony with Wilson's views on Belgium than Sir W. Nicholson had been. Wilson had come to consider the latter "hopeless". (Wilson Diary, 6 Sept., 31 Dec. 1911, 7 Jan. 1912). He believed Nicholson did not even read his long paper of 20 Sept. 1911 and that he refused to allow it to be circulated. French, on the other hand, was highly complimentary about it and arranged for it to be printed for the C.I.D. (*ibid.* 28 Oct. 1911, 20 Mar., 12, 17, 19 Apr. 1912). He also supported at the C.I.D. in Apr. 1912 the idea that the attitude of the Belgians would make an immense difference to a British army employed on the Continent (Minutes of 116th meeting, 25 Apr. 1912, CAB 2/2/3).

1. Williamson, *op. cit.* pp. 217-18.

2. CAB, 42/1/2.

3. The Wilson Diary records a discussion between himself, Grierson, Haig and Paget on 17 Nov. 1912 in which there were "some amazing contributions to strategy and a general want of knowledge and clear thinking". French, who in Mar. 1911 had the idea of having flat-bottomed boats full of troops towed up the Rhine to form a *point d'appui*, aptly described by Wilson as "AMAZING" (*ibid.* 20 Mar. 1911), revived in Aug. 1914 an idea for landing at Antwerp. This was not possible then because naval protection did not extend so far north (*ibid.* 3 Aug. 1914, CAB 42/1/2). Both Haig especially and French were not absolutely convinced that Britain should not wait for some months before crossing to the Continent (Wilson Diary, 5 Aug. 1914).

4. See Wilson questioned by Churchill at 16th meeting of C.I.D. Sub-Committee on Invasion, 12 Nov. 1913, CAB 16/28A, and Wilson note 17 Oct. 1912 on his paper of 20 Sept. 1911 in Cameron Hazlehurst, *Politicians at War* (London, 1971), p. 319.

5. Wilson to Seely, 21 Oct. 1912, W.O. 106/48.

6. See my article 'The British Decision for War: 2 August 1914', *British Journal of International Studies*, i (1975), pp. 148-59.

there can, as Hazlehurst says, be no doubt about the significance of the Cabinet's decision of 1 August "that we could not propose to Parliament *at this moment* to send an expeditionary military force to the continent".¹

J. A. Pease, for example, president of the Board of Education, wrote on 3 August: "... to resign at this moment only adds to the necessity of finding more warlike instruments and colleagues, who may go further than we are prepared to go and might urge our troops being sent abroad and so extend the field of our troubles."² Once the ultimatum to Germany expired, however, Britain and France were both at war with Germany. Then, the sending of the B.E.F. to France was also a political decision. It followed from the first. It too was based on "the policy of the *Entente*".

The sense of the War Councils held on 5 and 6 August 1914 was that four divisions and a cavalry division should be sent to France to await events and to be ready to do as the French wished. This was the view of Sir John French, of Lord Roberts, of Sir Charles Douglas and of Haig. No decision was taken as to the line of operations and on 6 August French and Kitchener agreed with Hamilton's suggestion of the 5th that concentration should not be further forward than Amiens.³ There may have been some military reasons for this decision: to try to join up with the Belgian army might have involved a flank march, a risky operation; and there was the possibility, raised before and raised now by Haig, of "defeat in detail".⁴ There was more safety in numbers.

Political considerations, however, were the overriding ones. In the 1908-9 sub-committee both the Foreign Office and the General Staff had stressed the "moral effect" on the French of the co-operation of English soldiers - what Grant-Duff in July 1908 had called "the undoubted moral and political effect on the French Army and the French nation of the ocular presence" of a British force in the field. Esher had presumed, correctly as it turned out, that political considerations would govern the sending of some assistance to give "that moral support upon which stress has been laid".⁵ In August 1911 both Grey and Wilson admitted that the moral value of the B.E.F. was greater than, perhaps double, its material value⁶; and on 2 August 1914 Paul Cambon, in Grey's words, "dwelt on the moral effect of our sending only two divisions".⁷ The War Councils, attended only by those ministers - Asquith, Grey, Haldane, Churchill - who had most identified themselves with the *Entente*, had been called to further

1. Hazlehurst, *op. cit.* p. 87, my italics.

2. Pease to his wife, 3 Aug. 1914, and similarly on 2 Aug., Gainford MSS. 521.

3. CAB 42/1/2, 3. Also R. Blake (ed.), *The Private Papers of Douglas Haig 1914-19* (London, 1952), pp. 68-70. On 12 Aug. Wilson claimed that Maubeuge had been agreed upon as concentration area. This was not so. Wilson Diary, 5, 12 Aug. 1914.

4. CAB 42/1/2; Wilson at 114th C.I.D. CAB 2/2/2 p. 9; enclosure in Nicholson to Haldane, 16 Dec. 1911, ADM 116/3474.

5. Memo. by Grant-Duff, July 1908, W.O. 106/46; C.I.D. Sub-Committee, appendixes IV, VII and minutes of meeting, 23 Mar. 1909, CAB 16/5.

6. 114th C.I.D., CAB 2/2/2, p. 5. Also memo. by Churchill, 13 Aug. 1911, CAB 38/19/50.

7. Grey to Bertie, 2 Aug. 1914, B.D. xi, no. 487; and see memo. by Major Ollivant, 1 Aug. 1914 in Hazlehurst, *op. cit.* p. 326.

to the greatest extent possible in the circumstances the *Entente* policy. The B.E.F. was sent off because it existed; to France because it was thought the French needed it, because all pre-war planning had been for the sake of the French and the premise for it that the French would otherwise be defeated; because Britain and France were now in effect allies, because it was acknowledged that naval force alone could not force a decision, and because Grey had said, for instance in April 1907 that, should Britain fight, she would do so with all her resources, naval and military.¹ When the Cabinet heard the War Council's decision it was not disposed to argue. It had, after all, only just survived the decision for war. It had no wish to repeat the process when the outcome was sure to be the same.²

When war came there was no obligation on the British government springing from the military conversations themselves. Nor was the "French" plan adopted because it was the only one that had been worked out.³ The existence of a plan, or of plans, was no more decisive than the lack of them had been in November 1908, when Asquith, Grey and Haldane had all been ready to send a force to the Continent.⁴ The plans only helped, only removed the need to improvise. They did not compel.⁵

What did compel the course of action adopted was the *Entente* itself, which the conversations were only part of and subsidiary to. Grey himself had always insisted that such obligation as there was resided in the *Entente*. He had told the House of Commons on 30 March 1911:

The extent of the obligation to which Great Britain was committed was that expressed or *implied* in the Anglo-French Convention laid before Parliament.⁶

As he told the French, this had been so worded "as not to convey that the engagement of 1904 might not under certain circumstances be construed to have larger consequences than its strict letter".⁷ Although Grey and the Cabinet had withstood Paul Cambon's attempts of late 1912 to make the conversations binding, Grey had not challenged Cambon's remark of that summer:

1. Esher, *Journals*, *op. cit.* iii, p. 175, 178, 6, 14 Aug. 1914; Grey to Bertie, 13, 19 Apr. 1907, B.D. vi, nos. 10, 14; Balfour to Haldane, 4 Aug. 1914, Balfour MSS. Add. MSS. 49724.

2. Asquith's announcement to the Cabinet, however, was couched in very reassuring terms: "the big experts . . . all urged an expeditionary force should be landed and kept on our right hand of naval force – not on left hand of French force necessary – they would not be wiped out as they could always retire to the sea, even in event of France being overwhelmed." Pease Diary, 6 Aug. 1914, Gainford MSS.

3. Lord Hankey, *The Supreme Command 1914–18* (London, 1961), i, pp. 170–1.

4. Esher, *Journals* *op. cit.* ii, p. 359; Huguet to Picquart, 9 Nov. 1908 D.D.F., 2nd series, xi, no. 558; Hardinge to Nicolson, 11 Nov. 1908: "the question of British intervention in the event of a Franco-German conflict – the possibility of which is now happily removed – has been the subject of discussion here during the past week." Hardinge MSS., vol. 13.

5. Williamson *op. cit.* p. 367; Hardinge in C.I.D. Sub-Committee, Proceedings of 23 Mar. 1909, CAB 16/5.

6. B.D. vii, no. 197, *my italics*.

7. Grey to Bertie, 10 Apr 1911, *ibid.* no. 206; see also note by Nicolson, 2 Nov. 1911 and minute by Grey, *ibid.* no. 617.

there was nothing but a moral *Entente*, which might, however, be transformed into a formal *Entente* if the two Governments desired, when an occasion arose.¹

Britain's military options, then, were reduced to that taken by political considerations. Her freedom of action in August 1914 was prejudiced and curtailed only by the inflexibility of her pre-war foreign policy. If the definition of a healthy foreign policy as one in which there was a real possibility of a change of policy may be allowed to stand, then that of Great Britain had long since become unhealthy. Like all the other Great Powers, Britain had been too much committed, for too long, to a particular policy and a particular Power. Her military planners had produced alternative schemes. No provision had been made for an alternative foreign policy.

1. B.D. xi (ii), nos. 415, 400. It was in this sense that Charles Trevelyan was right when he wrote "The *Entente* was an alliance after all, no less real in Edward Grey's mind because it was not written". Trevelyan to Runciman, 4 Aug. 1914, Runciman MSS.